



2nd Ubuntu Special Needs and Inclusive Education Conference

16th - 18 th August

Report



Contents

Program.....	3
Conference hosts	3
Welcoming note: EVA NAPUTUNI OGW-ASNEN Chair	3
Agenda	3
Keynote Addresses and Speakers	6
Mr. Chuhi Nyoike- Acorn Special Tutorials	6
Clifford Oluoch- Principal, Regis School	7
Solomon Munene - National Vice Chairman at Kenya Private Schools Association	7
Dr. Janette Karimi- Ministry of Health, Division of Newborn- presenting Susan Nakhumicha's speech (CS Health).....	7
Speaker: Ellenah Wangui- World Vision	8
No Child Left Behind- A Multi-Sectoral Approach to Inclusion	8
Closing Remarks by Kpsa Vc- Mr. Solomon Munene	11
Panel Discussions and Workshops	12
Panel 1: The Developing Child- A Holistic Overview (to include special needs)	12
Moderator. Dr Susan Wamithi	12
Panel 2: Nurturing Care and The Benefits of Responsive Caregiving	13
Moderator: Beatrice Oyugi	14
Panel 3: No Child Left Behind	17
Moderator: Yukabeth Kidenda- Co-founder and CEO for Teach for Kenya	17
Panel discussions:	19
Highlights and Key Findings.....	22
Breakout session- discussion groups of 3.....	22
Conclusions.....	25
Exhibitions and Demonstrations	27
Exhibitors and information Booth List	27
Case Studies.....	27
Case Study: Nuru and Jana.....	27
Participation and Attendee Demographics.....	28
Sponsors and Partners.....	30
Challenges and Lessons Learned	32
Challenges:	32
Lessons learned:.....	32
Recommendations.....	33
Photo Gallery	33
Conclusion	41

APPENDIX I	42
Why Ubuntu? – Mr Chuhi Nyoike.....	42
APPENDIX II	43
Transformative Power of Ubuntu Philosophy- Eva Naputuni Nyoike	43
APPENDIX III	46
Closing Remarks by Kpsa Vice Chairman-Mr. Solomon Munene	46

Program

Conference hosts

- Mildred Obuya- Director-Child matters
- Antony Muriithi- Associate Elimika Kenya
- Sammy Brayo- Motivational Speaker, Award Winning musician, Swimmer, Footballer

Welcoming note: EVA NAPUTUNI OGW-ASNEN Chair

“Today, I'm excited to discuss Ubuntu's philosophy in special needs and inclusive education. Ubuntu reminds us of our shared humanity, offering a chance to transform how we approach education. It's about recognizing everyone's unique contributions, breaking down barriers, and fostering empathy and collaboration in the classroom. This journey may have challenges, but the rewards are enormous. Let's commit to this noble cause, guided by Ubuntu, and work together to create a more inclusive, compassionate, and enlightened world through education. Thank you for being here.”

Agenda

Time	Topic	Presenters

16/08/2023		
8:30-9:30 am	Welcoming and opening	Antony Muriithi KPSA Secretariat
10:30-12 pm	An Analytical View of Inclusive Education; What does inclusive education mean in your sector?	Juliet Wangui, Diana Autt MODERATOR: Lilly Oyare PANELISTS Mr. Fred Haga Richard Mativu Sophia Wanyeki Karen Muriuki Mutheu Kasanga Nelly Mukuria
2.00 – 3.15 pm	BREAKOUT ROOMS (Two Rooms with the Same Topic) TOPIC: Is your education system best suited to support Inclusive Education and Care in the Early Years? (Sharing evidence of Practice)	REAKOUT A: MODERATOR: Cliff Oluoch. BREAKOUT B: MODERATOR: Solomon Munene
17/08/2023		
9.05 – 10.30 am	KEYNOTE ADDRESS & REFLECTIONS The Developing Child, a holistic overview (to include special needs)	Dr. Susan Wamithi & Inclusion Champions Dr. Jane Muiruri (Parent) Andrew (Occupational Therapist) Val Kathambi (Clinical Psychologist)
Panel Discussion	Nurturing care and the benefits of responsive caregiving.	MODERATOR: Beatrice Oyugi PANELISTS Dr. Roseline Olumbe (Early Learning Opportunities) Murrissa Gitau (Nutrition)

11.30 – 1.00 pm	Understanding the Nurturing Care Framework	Dr. Ciriaka Gitonga (Safety & Security) Mr. Mutua (Health) David Mbau (Parent) Ruth Kihiu (Occupational Therapist)
2.00 – 3.15pm	BREAKOUT ROOMS (Two Rooms with the Same Topic) TOPIC: A Case Study – a look into best practices for early identification and Intervention	Dr. Becky Isanda MODERATOR: Lazarus Omusula
18/08/2023 Panel Discussion 10.35 – 12.00 pm	No Child Left Behind – A multi-sectoral approach to inclusion	MODERATOR: Yukabeth Kidenda PANELISTS The Panelists will be broken into 2 Groups: Group 1 Marthi Sunda (116 Child Helpline) Dr. Kiingati John Bosco (Mental Health) Mr. Frederick Ruoro (MD - CIC Insurance) Eva Naputuni OGW (Education) Dr. George Owino (AfECN) Group 2

12.15 – 1.30 pm (Group discussion)	A Call to Action – What can I bring to the table?	Maureen (Domestic Workers) Cosma Gatere (Parents) KISE (Specialized Trainers) Joy Doreen (Media) KCB (Banking Industry) Hamminton Mwenda – Save the Children (NGO) MODERATOR: ANTONY MURIITHI
3.05 – 3.30	Closing remarks	MILDRED OBUYA

Keynote Addresses and Speakers

Mr. Chuhi Nyoike- Acorn Special Tutorials

Introduced the conference as well as an introduction to the Ubuntu philosophy

Why Ubuntu?

According to Mr. Nyoike, everyone has unique traits that allow them to adapt to their environment and surroundings. These traits allow people to be uniquely identified from other groups and are called culture. The African culture is characterized by the Spirit of abundance and justice, Matriarchy, Emancipation of women, Territoriality, Xenophilia, Cosmopolitanism, Social Collectivism, Material solidarity, Optimism, and a literature emphasizing novel tales and comedy.

Ubuntu: I am because we are!

Clifford Oluoch- Principal, Regis School

The curriculum never met his needs, so he moved to international systems. Key things that we need to ask ourselves:

Question on IE

- 1) Was the last homework that was given differentiated?
- 2) Was the last exam/assessment differentiated?
- 3) Why isn't schoolwork differentiated?

Solomon Munene - National Vice Chairman at Kenya Private Schools Association

- Support inclusivity in the education system.
- Sensitize Kenyans to consider children and persons with disabilities in the public and private education sectors.
- Need to advocate for inclusivity in schools.
- The 2-6-3-3 system developed by KICD is a framework that has the needs of children at heart.
- Segregation has been practiced in Kenya since the inception of SNE, with the establishment of special schools.
- Age-based curriculum recommends matching age with grades, and with the CBC, children are having stage-based learning, Foundation, Intermediate, Prevocational, and vocational.
- It also provides room for transition to higher education.
- The presidential report will provide recommendations for reforms, including the Basic Education Act, TSC Act, and KNEC, to be changed to Kenya National Assessment Council.
- Rules and regulations will be amended, including the special needs. The law will be passed in parliament, and the CS will make regulations.

Dr. Janette Karimi- Ministry of Health, Division of Newborn- presenting Susan Nakhumicha's speech (CS Health)

Children under five years should be well cared for since their brain capacity is still growing during this time.

*Guidelines

- ✓ Health ministry plays more of a prevention role. The wellness of the mother is, therefore, very important.
- ✓ Early intervention can change the trajectories of children despite delays in milestones.
- ✓ Inclusion has been previously practiced through communal practices on nurturing children.
- ✓ SDG 4 emphasizes the need for children to access education, which is impacted by the health of the child in the first 1,000 days.
- ✓ Brain development takes place from birth till age 5. This provides a window to prevent neurodiverse abilities.
- ✓ The impact felt because of a disability is profound exclusion, poverty, and health issues.
- ✓ Persons with disabilities represent 2.2% of the Kenyan population.
- ✓ Strategies that the MoH has implemented concerning disabilities:
 - Early identification of disabilities.
 - Launch of rehabilitative services and assistive technology services.
 - Building on Human Resources capacity to support persons with disabilities.
 - Develop persons with disabilities through passing acts for identification, rehabilitation, and intervention.
 - Guidelines in the categorization of disabilities and decentralization of assessment services to county levels.
 - Prioritize vaccination of the mother, provision of supplements, and awareness programs for pregnant women.
 - Maternal child feeding programs, child vaccination, identification, referral, and prevention of illnesses.
- ✓ There is a need to collaborate in the categorization of children with disabilities.

Speaker: Ellenah Wangui- World Vision

No Child Left Behind- A Multi-Sectoral Approach to Inclusion

World Vision has a project to enhance learning in the community. It is a Christian organization that seeks to follow Jesus' example.

- Mission: to follow the work of Jesus Christ

Values

- ✓ Value people
- ✓ Responsive
- ✓ Stewards

✓ Committed

Strategic goal: **To improve and sustain the well-being of 8,827,654, including 2,521,600 children and 1,487,744 identified as most vulnerable children by the year 2025.**

Strategy is guided by a promise they want to achieve: Building Brighter Futures for Vulnerable.

1. No child is left behind through the 2030 agenda and Sustainable Development (SDG) Framework.
2. All children are protected from violence.
3. Rights for all children are prioritized in response to humanitarian crises.
4. Supported children are experiencing more than one vulnerability.
 - Serious discrimination – disabled or with chronic illness.
 - Abuse, violence, and exploitation- neglected and abused / child labor.
 - Extreme deprivation- orphans and those who lack basic needs.
 - Vulnerability to disaster and catastrophe

Technical programs and sectoral priorities:

1. Child protection and participation
2. Integrated Health and WASH
3. Community engagement and sponsorship
4. Child Learning and Household Resilience

What WV is doing concerning the vulnerable child.

- ✓ Programs to ensure child protection and participation- Walk with children they pick from 0-3 years.
- ✓ Prepare mothers and fathers before a child is born and ensure they can access early learning opportunities.
- ✓ Work with the children and their caregivers.
- ✓ Help the family to strengthen them to provide food and other needs.
- ✓ Help families to try and access other needs.

Models to achieve the strategic goals:

- ✓ **Go baby go model-** a curriculum used to train parents and caregivers on the nurturing care framework so that they can track mental milestones. Promote positive parenting conduct and support parents to get assessments for their children. Positive parenting empowers parents of children with disabilities as direct caregivers and advocates to ensure accessibility and diversity.

- ✓ **Learning roots model**- to support teachers and parents through responsive caregiving. It also looks at the child ecologically, seeing the environmental conditions of the child. Geared towards achievements of SDG 4 on Quality Education aimed at ensuring inclusive and equitable quality education and promoting lifelong learning opportunities for all.
- ✓ **Learning through play model**- these interactive activities help children learn easily. There are also community-based learning centers that implement these activities. Parents/caregivers, teachers, and teachers are supported to help create an enabling school, home, and community environment to support play and academic success.

GESI- Gender Equity and Social Inclusion

- An approach used by WV in selecting activities. Every program done by the organization should follow these criteria. The approach provides access to various materials and opportunities, has systems for these activities, encourages participation, and teaches decision-making to promote well-being.
- The GESI approach enhances:
 - Access to services and opportunities
 - Improving well-being.
 - Facilitating participation in education, social, economic, and cultural activities.
 - Engaging children with disabilities in decision-making.
 - Tackling systems that discriminate against children with disabilities.

Challenges facing inclusion in ECD.

- ✓ It is significantly underfunded.
- ✓ Not a priority for donors.
- ✓ The absence of systematic attention and social systems deprives the children of the opportunity to develop their full potential.
- ✓ Poorly trained personnel.
- ✓ Complex multi-sectoral collaboration.

Why invest in children?

- ✓ Investing in children has a higher economic return.
- ✓ 1USD invested = 17.24USD return on investment.
- ✓ It saves lives and promotes social equity and yield.

Promising practices for inclusion in ECD

- ❖ Ensure every child is valued, is seen, and families are empowered.

- ❖ An integrated approach or disability-inclusive programming in ECD is needed to target the nutrition, health, and sanitation sectors.
- ❖ Advocate for transformative development.
- ❖ Systematic planning / Build ECD systems that deliver equity and inclusion.
- ❖ Support participation and decision-making for children with disabilities and enhance services through Citizen Voice and Action, World Vision's social accountability model,
- ❖ Early screening, Identification, and referral
- ❖ Address stigma through supporting parents better to meet the needs of their children with disabilities and manage any societal stigma towards their children.
- ❖ Systematic planning / Build ECD systems that deliver equity and inclusion.

Closing Remarks by Kpsa Vc- Mr. Solomon Munene

Challenges facing inclusive education:

- 1) Inadequate teacher training.
- 2) Underdeveloped Identification and Assessment processes.
- 3) Limited monitoring and evaluation of special education policies.
- 4) Limited funding.
- 5) Little or Lack of information on Special Needs Education and Care Giving among the members of the public, parents, and educators.
- 6) Negative attitudes and perceptions on Special Needs Education and Learners with Special Education Needs.
- 7) Fear to Embrace Special Needs Education

Recommendations for these challenges:

- 1) Increased and effective Special Education Needs Assessment and intervention.
- 2) Increased Advocacy and Awareness.
- 3) Increased Funding in the Special Needs Education Sector
- 4) Enhanced Continuous Capacity Building and Development for educators.

- 5) Review the Teachers' Training Curriculum to include Mandatory Compressive Training of Special Needs Education for all Teachers.
- 6) Research and documentation.
- 7) Increased Accessibility to Specialized facilities and Technology.
- 8) Special Incentives by the GoK for Private Education Institutions offering Inclusive Education (If the institution has achieved a set minimum number of learners, let's say 35 learners).
- 9) Tax waiver for all Special Needs Learning facilities and equipment.
- 10) Free and Easy access to Specialized and General Health and Medical Treatment for all children with special needs.

Panel Discussions and Workshops

Panel 1: The Developing Child- A Holistic Overview (to include special needs)

Moderator. Dr Susan Wamithi



- The development domains of a child are mainly focused on.
 - ✓ Gross motor skills
 - ✓ Fine motor skills- textures
 - ✓ Speech and language skills- how much we speak.
 - ✓ Cognitive development
 - ✓ Socio-emotional environment
- We are no longer abusing the term special needs; instead, we include all of them.
- A family setting is the first environment where the children learn.
- How to make progress in ensuring accessibility in infrastructure, i.e., wide enough doors for wheelchair
- This allows inclusion in all domains of life.
- International Classification of Function (ICF) classification is based on interactions with the environment and their abilities.
- Functioning- Set goals on functional development to ensure individual needs are met.
- The family setting is the child's first learning environment. Parents set goals for their children.
- Collaboration with parents to ensure parents' psychological well-being is maintained due to having children with disabilities.
- Need to be accessibility in sports so that children can participate in sports to prevent cardiovascular diseases in their old age due to lack of play.

Panel 2: Nurturing Care and The Benefits of Responsive Caregiving



Moderator: Beatrice Oyugi

- ✓ ECD- early childhood development (from 0-8yrs)
- ✓ Ages 0-4 years do not go to any school but need to develop.
- ✓ The health status of a mother depends on the environment she is in
- ✓ Childcare should begin with preconception.
- ✓ The quality of the baby given birth to depends on the environment of the pregnant mother.
- ✓ There are two types of development:
 - i. Surviving.
 - ii. Thriving.

Development starts during pregnancy and at conception.

The brain is most sensitive during early ages.

The more the baby hears words, the more they internalize, and it would be easier for them to learn.

✓ Why ECD?

- Many children survive rather than live. The 1st 1,000 days of life are very critical to the development of the child since, during that time, their brains develop very fast. If there is no stimulation for the child, their neurons get pruned.
- ✓ Many things in the environment can hinder the baby's growth.
- ✓ The nurturing care framework was launched by the World Health Assembly in 2018. It refers to conditions created in the environment that ensure children get good health, nutrition, responsive caregiving, security and safety, and opportunities for early learning. It essentially means taking care of a child's brain to grow well.
- ✓ All children need nurturing care, but some children need extra.
- ✓ When we invest in the early years of a child, we will reap the best returns on our investment as there will be minimal problems.

Nurturing:

Public policies and programs create conditions for children to get adequate nutrition, responsive caregiving, security and safety, good health, and opportunities for early learning.

Adequate nutrition and good health should be both for the mother and the child. Nurturing is necessary for their growth. Early interventions lead to massive reaping.

**How does nurturing care get implemented in the child?*

- Providing material that provides opportunities to learn. Children come out ready to learn, giving good academic results.
- Responsive caregiving- Learning starts at home. The parent or the first primary giver is the first teacher.

**How can different sectors come together to ensure the safety and security of the children?*

- All sectors, including medical space, parents, teachers, and many more, should know what it takes to offer security and safety for the children.
- Promoting special needs education
- To support the establishment of the one-stop centers

**What are some programs in the health ministry that encourage nurturing care*

- Health starts with preconception. ANC clinics are critical to offer counseling during pregnancy and after pregnancy.
- Hygiene is very important to avoid illness.
- Both the baby and the health care of the baby are equally important.
- After delivery: ANC clinics with hygiene, health of the mother, vaccination

**Interventions in nutrition that encourage nurturing care and how accessible are they?*

- Both nutrition for the mother and the father are important.
- Child's nutrition- If the child's nutrition is okay, development will happen well.
- Mother's nutrition affects the baby as it passes through breast milk.

**How do you support children with special needs and their caregivers*

- Most children with disabilities who go for occupational therapy have delayed developmental challenges such as Autism (higher rate), ADHD, delayed speech, and hyperactivity, which can cause self-harm.
- The occupational therapist offers services to SNE patients referred to them.
- Early intervention is important.
- Through occupational therapy, weight control, sitting, eating, and cognitive exercises, i.e., Problem-solving.

**Challenges parents experience in caregiving, especially those dealing with special children*

- Ignorance on disorders
- Emotional fatigue
- The dilemma comes with testing to see if the child has a disorder.
- Limited resources as the children are growing- quality life.
- Advocacy- forced to become an advocate for the child.
- Slow down your life.
- Social isolation- people being too careful around you.
- Planning the future for the children
- Not having answers (for the siblings)

**What does providing responsive caregiving mean*

- The ability of caregivers to provide a keen response to a child's actions.
- Observation, interpretation, and action
- When the action takes longer, it confuses the child, and feelings of rejection come in.
- When the response is there, trust is built in children. The whole difference is made by the speed with which the caregiver acts.

Contribution from the attendees:

- Find a way to engage the community through the various fields people are in.
- One of the biggest gaps is documentation (no books) to guide young parents.

Comments: Look for appropriate material to help support parenting and health care (KLB has a lot of literature on childhood care)

- Look at and engage marginalized communities that are far from Nairobi.
- Have a midwife on the panel.

Questions from the attendees:

- Is standing out a bad thing? *A repetitive environment does not stop them unless they realize they are anxious.*
- When do you talk to parents about special needs?
- Contact support groups info? *To be shared by panelists.*
- Things you do to self-care (David)? *Joined a support group.*
- How do you receive advice gotten from professionals? *Join support groups and invite professionals to the support groups.*
- How are you helping others going through the situation? *Reaching out to them*
- How can every school have at least one child safety lead?
- Children who move well, then suddenly, they change. *Observe, then go to the doctor; do not rush to go to the doctor.*

Panel 3: No Child Left Behind

Moderator: Yukabeth Kidenda- Co-founder and CEO for Teach for Kenya

- ❖ Trains fellows and places them in the most underprivileged schools.
- ❖ Focus on removing barriers that hinder children from accessing education.
- ❖ Challenges: accessibility, poverty, lack of teachers, gender-based violence, and period poverty

- ❖ Ensure children access education despite their socioeconomic status.

Mr Hamminton Mwenda shared that Save the Children has identified disability inclusion as a key focus area within its broader education strategy and have undertaken several initiatives to promote inclusion. This includes:

- Collaborating with device and content providers who cater to learners and teachers with disabilities, aiming to bridge existing gaps
- Advocating for policies that are more inclusive and raising awareness about the needs of persons with disabilities (PWD)
- Conducting impact evaluations and facilitating discussions to assess the current landscape's effectiveness

He emphasised the importance of continuous engagement with industry stakeholders whilst still regularly assessing their impact in the community, and ensuring they identify areas of improvement and constructively contribute to the ongoing dialogue as a sign of their strong commitment on inclusion agenda.

Joachim Kamau- 116 child helpline

Run the 116-government line to report cases of child issues.

In inclusion, they:

- ✓ Listen, help provide psychosocial support, and refer for relevant services.
- ✓ In emergencies, they ensure safety.
- ✓ Provides help to children in distress around the country and connects them to government services.
- ✓ You can call 116 or write 0722116116, or email info@childlinekenya.co.ke.

Dr. Kiingati John Bosco- Afro heritage consultancies.

- ✓ Journeys with young people to help them realize their full potential.
- ✓ A counseling psychologist started an organization.
- ✓ Provides psychosocial support to young people and engages youth groups in public primary schools and slums to ensure character development.

Dr. Kang'e- CIC Group

- ✓ Works with insurance to ensure the needs of all persons are met.
- ✓ Health and education policies for children, including ones who are differently abled.

Eva Nyoike- ASNEN

- ✓ Acorn Special Tutorials was a school for neurodiversity. Started to reverse inclusion as they noted children struggled to rejoin the mainstream school due to a lack of resources.

- ✓ Encourages inclusion by getting parents to bring the other siblings, not only the differently abled, to learn alongside the special children.
- ✓ We must look at the community when working with children with disabilities to ensure social inclusion. This ensures no child is left behind.

Dr. George Owino- Africa Early Childhood network

- ✓ Building collaboration and supporting partnerships to ensure the environment.
- ✓ Sharing information on different platforms

Moreen Agamala- Nyarai Home Care Services

- ✓ placement agency for domestic managers
- ✓ Trained managers by Acorn to ensure they can support children with disabilities.
- ✓ Train them in their role and how to ensure a conducive environment.
- ✓ Info@nyaraicarehomes.com 0115972828

Cosma Gatere- parent

- ✓ Looking after the child from birth. It is a multi-stakeholder rolled into one.
- ✓ The role of the caregiver is diverse and cuts across different areas to ensure child development.
- ✓ The parent also acts as a mentor to the child.
- ✓ Has been key in founding the Down Syndrome Society of Kenya, which reaches out to parents of children with Down syndrome. This allows parents to be part of the government in drafting policies and acts. This allows them to champion the rights of their children.

Mr. Clive- Bian Shitwa - Agimba and Associates Advocates

- ✓ Help children who are differently abled after their parents depart. Help schools set up policies and prepare tax consultations.
- ✓ Preventive law- trusts and wills
- ✓ Allows children with disabilities to ensure they are not disadvantaged when sharing inheritance.
- ✓ Helped to develop policies for schools and taxation policies to ensure they are friendly to children with disabilities.
- ✓ 0712050936- info@agimba-advocates.co.ke

Panel discussions:

What is your understanding of a multisectoral approach to inclusion?

- Article 27- Rights of discriminated people, including those with disabilities. The current approaches are not enough.

- The policies being enacted allow us to meet the needs of all children.
- We need to engage lawyers to sensitize parents on the approach to special needs.
- Article 45- Need for a family. Schools around Nairobi do not accommodate children from single families. The education sector ought to streamline this to reduce the stigma and exclusion of children.
- The Children's Act 2022 talks of the rights of intersex children. Schools have rarely adapted to meet the needs of intersex children, such as wash facilities and dorms.
- Ensure all policies are triangulated to ensure the education acts are fully implemented.
- Advocate for accessibility as it leads to exclusion.
- Education- ensuring children are included without any discrimination.
- Transportation of children with special needs.

Who are the most important stakeholders to come together to ensure multisectoral?

- **State actors-** national and county governments
- **Non-state actors-** INGOs, CBOs, FBOs, DPOs
- Health Partners
- Parents are the champions and should have access to information. They need to insist on their rights.

What measures have been implemented to ensure information is available to stakeholders?

- ✓ Collaborating with others to get the word out through conferences.
- ✓ Sharing different ideas via various activities.
- ✓ Collect information, such as in a hub.
- ✓ Convene meetings for people to share experiences.
- ✓ Organizes regional conferences
- ✓ Organize webinars.
- ✓ Working with actors.
- ✓ Research.
- ✓ Transmit evidence to be used by practitioners.

How do we bring partners with shared objectives together to get more on inclusion?

- ✓ ASNEN is reaching out to people in the field of disability.
- ✓ Knowledge and information sharing with networks.
- ✓ Appreciate the different sectors that play a key role in inclusion.
- ✓ Need to have more conferences.

How do government agencies deal with the allocation of resources and manage the project of catering for special children?

- ✓ Preventative measures to ensure we do not get to the stage of responding.
- ✓ Ensuring the protection of children in the online space
- ✓ Ensure accessibility in schools to ease interaction with the environment.
- ✓ Sensitive parents to ensure they are aware of the child's environment both online and offline.

What are the gaps in the execution of inclusion?

- ✓ Excluding a child from benefits because they are differently abled.
- ✓ CIC does not exit dependents who are differently abled from insurance than other insurance groups.
- ✓ Innovation is in limited spheres.
- ✓ Sometimes, parents insure all other children and exclude those with disabilities.
- ✓ In the declaration of beneficiaries, they also tend to leave them out.
- ✓ There is a need to sensitize parents on the need to accept disability and discuss this, as has been done on gender.
- ✓ CIC allows children with disabilities to be life dependents at age 18 and above.

How do Nyarai Homes tailor-make homecare programs to support children who can learn differently?

- ✓ Partnership with Arcon tutorials.
- ✓ Provide space for parents to share information on their children.
- ✓ They can place domestic managers to ensure they understand the work environment.

What are you doing to support the community in the right frame of mind to advance the agenda?

- ✓ Inclusivity vs. exclusivity. Persons with disabilities are part of nature.
- ✓ Parents majorly blame themselves; most of the time, the fathers associate the disability with the mother.
- ✓ Teachers, at times those with no training in inclusive education, push children with disabilities to teachers who are trained.
- ✓ There is a need to change our attitudes towards children with disabilities.
- ✓ They provide services, individually or in group sessions, to teachers, learners, and parents to help shape the mindset of people towards disability.

Highlights and Key Findings

Breakout session- discussion groups of 3

Task: What you would like the education system to do for you as a.

1. Teacher



- Retraining of the teacher on SNE
- Training of teachers on inclusive education.
- Ensure mainstreaming of children with disabilities.
- Need to have classroom assistants to support the regular teacher.
- Recruitment of trained teachers in schools where the teacher-learner ratio is high.
- All teachers should be trained in IE, not only those specializing in SNE, to create awareness.
- Psychosocial support.

2. Parent



- Develop common and need-based materials to help the learner at home and school.
- Availability of resources in the market.
- Provide parents with programs to identify and take a child to assessment, recommend children to SNE schools, provision of non-formal materials, e.g., wheelchairs.
- Train teachers to understand the needs of children and accept them.

3. Students with disabilities



- Give them equal rights in assessment.
- Give them specialized exams which are based on the child's competency.
- Need for shadow teachers for support inside and outside the classroom.
- Adaptation of the school environment to make it accessible.
- Curriculum adaptation and differentiation.
- Provision of trained and specialized teachers.
- Give them time to express themselves.
- Provision of adapted learning materials.

- Need to have sensory rooms that are well-equipped.
- There is a need to create awareness among learners and teachers to change their attitudes on disabilities.
- Partner with universities to ensure a smooth transition.

Mildred Obuya

"The curious case of Benjamin Button"

Reflection: If you had power to reverse time, what would you do differently?

During the conference on, several important discussions, debates, and conclusions were reached:

- **Engaging the Community:** Attendees emphasized the need to engage various fields within the community to support inclusive education effectively. This involvement would help break down barriers and foster understanding among community members.
- **Documentation and Parenting Support:** Participants identified a significant gap in documentation and resources to guide young parents in supporting children with special needs. It was suggested that appropriate materials, such as those provided by KLB (Kenya Literature Bureau), could be valuable in this regard, particularly in parenting and healthcare.
- **Marginalized Communities:** Attendees stressed the importance of reaching out to marginalized communities, especially those far from urban centers like Nairobi, to ensure that inclusive education efforts are widespread and not limited to urban areas.
- **Involvement of Professionals:** A midwife was recommended on the panel, highlighting the need for diverse expertise when discussing inclusive education and child development.
- **Understanding Special Needs:** Questions were raised about when and how to talk to parents about special needs and where to find information on support groups.
- **Self-Care and Support Groups:** Attendees inquired about self-care strategies for parents and how to receive and share advice from professionals. Support groups were mentioned as a valuable resource.

- **Helping Others:** Attendees discussed the importance of reaching out and supporting others who are going through similar situations.
- **Child Safety Leads:** There was a question about ensuring that every school has at least one child safety lead.
- **Sudden Changes in Children:** Advice was given to observe children who suddenly change their behavior, emphasizing the importance of careful observation before rushing to seek medical attention.
- **Multisectoral Approach to Inclusion:** Panelists discussed the need for a multisectoral approach to inclusion involving various stakeholders such as government agencies, non-governmental organizations, health partners, and parents. They emphasized the importance of aligning policies and laws to meet the needs of all children, including those with disabilities.
- **Information Sharing:** Measures to ensure information availability were highlighted, including collaborating through conferences, sharing ideas through activities and hubs, convening meetings for experience sharing, organizing webinars, and conducting research to provide evidence for practitioners.
- **Partnership Building:** Attendees explored strategies for bringing partners with shared inclusion objectives together, such as knowledge sharing, appreciation of diverse sectors' roles, and the organization of more conferences.
- **Resource Allocation:** Government agencies discussed preventive measures to allocate resources for special children's projects effectively, emphasizing protection in the online space and ensuring accessibility in schools.
- These discussions and insights highlighted the importance of collaboration, policy alignment, and community engagement in promoting inclusive education and ensuring no child is left behind. They also highlighted the significance of ongoing support, information sharing, and resource allocation to address the diverse needs of children with special requirements.

Conclusions

1. **Community Engagement is Essential:** Engaging various community stakeholders is crucial for the successful implementation of inclusive education. Involving community members can help break down barriers and foster understanding and support for children with special needs.
2. **Parental Support and Resources:** There is a significant need for resources and guidance to support young parents in caring for children with special needs. Materials

such as those provided by the Kenya Literature Bureau (KLB) can play a valuable role in parenting and healthcare.

3. **Reach Marginalized Communities:** Inclusive education efforts should extend beyond urban centers like Nairobi to reach marginalized communities. Access to inclusive education and support services should not be limited to urban areas.
4. **Diverse Expertise:** In discussions on inclusive education and child development, it's important to involve professionals with diverse expertise, including midwives, to provide a holistic perspective.
5. **Understanding Special Needs:** The timing and approach to discussing special needs with parents should be carefully considered. Information on support groups and resources for parents is essential.
6. **Self-Care and Support Groups:** Parents of children with special needs require self-care strategies, and support groups can be a valuable resource for sharing advice and experiences.
7. **Community Support:** Attendees emphasized the importance of reaching out and supporting others who are going through similar situations, fostering a sense of community and mutual assistance.
8. **Child Safety:** Efforts should be made to ensure that every school has at least one child safety lead, promoting the safety and well-being of all students.
9. **Observation and Behavioral Changes:** Careful observation of children who exhibit sudden behavioral changes is important before seeking medical attention, as it can provide valuable insights into their needs.
10. **Multisectoral Approach:** A multisectoral approach involving various stakeholders, including government agencies, NGOs, health partners, and parents, is essential for promoting inclusion. Aligning policies and laws to meet the needs of all children, including those with disabilities, is crucial.
11. **Information Sharing:** The importance of information sharing, and collaboration was highlighted, including through conferences, webinars, research, and the establishment of hubs for knowledge exchange.
12. **Partnership Building:** Strategies for building partnerships among organizations with shared inclusion goals include knowledge sharing, recognizing the roles of diverse sectors, and organizing collaborative events like conferences.
13. **Resource Allocation:** Effective resource allocation for projects supporting children with special needs, including online protection and accessible schools, is a preventive measure that should be prioritized.

Exhibitions and Demonstrations

Exhibitors and information Booth List

ITEM	NAME OF ORGANISATION	CONTACT PERSON
1	ELIMUTAB	CHARITY MWANGI
2	IFUNZA	LINDAH ACHIENG
3	WORLD VISION	ELLENA WANGUI
4	OPTICOM	REGINA OKONG'O
5	AGIMBA AND ASSOCIATES ADVOCATES	ANNE MUGWERE- AGIMBA
6	EASTERN AFRICA ACADEMY OF CHILDHOOD DISABILITY	ANDREW KHASIANI
7	THROUGH MY EYES	SHANICE MWANGI
8	SAVE THE CHILDREN	LUCY TENGEYE
9	ICEA	
10	GERTRUDE'S CHILDREN'S HOSPITAL	DIANA GACHUGI
11	WARIDI HEALTH	FLORA WAKHUDU
12	NYARAI HOME CARE SERVICES	MOREEN AGAMALA
13	KENYA LITERATURE BUREAU	LAURAINNE NYANGISA
14	SAMIMA RISE GARDENS	
15	KESTREL MANOR SCHOOL	CAROL WANJOHI
16	KURASA	WILLIAM NGURU
17	ANDY SPEAKS 4 SPECIAL NEEDS PERSONS AFRICA	DR. SYLVIA MOCHABO AKINSIKU

Case Studies

Case Study: Nuru and Jana

Advocates for Jana, Nuru's Mother.

- Take the child for early assessment in education assessment resource centers.
- Go for guidance and counseling since she suffers from stigma and is in denial.
- Join a support group to eradicate ignorance on her part.
- To advocate for her child to the community and make them understand it is not Nuru's fault.
- Try to bring the family back together and don't just ask for money from the father-
Parental involvement.
- Introduce her child to other children as their sister.
- Teach her to play and handle Nuru.

Advocates for Nuru

- Allow her to walk the journey with the teacher who she formed a connection with- walk with her.
- Expose her to a better assessment.
- Right to play
- The administration should allow Nuru to be admitted to the school since she shows signs of developing and forming a rapport with the other children.
- She should be given materials that help her develop various skills.
- She should be given a need-based education.
- The school should determine if the teacher can integrate Nuru into her regular class.
- Advise Nuru's mom to provide adequate nutrition for her.

The school also had a fundamental role in helping Jana, which they did not do so well. They could have handled it better than they did. They could have helped and walked with her to the best of their abilities.

Participation and Attendee Demographics

ITEM	NAME	ORGANIZATION
1	Moreen Agamala	Nyarai Home Services
2	John Githinji	Special Education Professionals
3	Elizabeth Gitau	Islamia College
4	Patricia Odipo	Pioneer Stars
5	Phanice T Lugalia	Juja Preparatory Schools
6	Sheela M. Mudachi	Juja Preparatory Schools
7	Lilian James Amakobe	Juja Preparatory Schools
8	Mary Kagiri	Furaha Centre
9	Eng. Peter Nduati	Individual
10	Daniel Muthiani	Ministry of Education (MOE)
11	Joseph Wafula	Save the Children
12	Johazel Tole	Save the Children
13	Moses Wokono	UASA - Kenya
14	Hillary Ochieng	KU
15	Laurainne Nyangisa	Kenya Literature Bureau
16	Veronica Wangui	KU
17	Evelyne Njeri Njimu	Sign language interpreter
18	Tobias Omondi	Sign language interpreter
19	Sarah Pacifica	Makini School
20	Asoro Silas	Makini School
21	Mercy Asimbah	Makini School

22	Vincencia Ochanda	Makini School
23	Caroline Kiini	Makini School
24	Vincent Shikwati	Makini School
25	Grace Kuigo	Makini School
26	Dorine Anyika	Makini School
27	Salome Maina	Makini School
28	Morris Mutanyi	Makini School
29	Michael Mucheru	Makini School
30	Joyce Lillian Anzemo	Makini School
31	Bennadatte Makatiani	Makini School
32	Jane Asitwa	Makini School
33	Joyce Ndung'u	Kidzone Tango
34	Ruth Wekesa	St. Don Bosco
35	Maxie Wekesa	Good Testimony Schools
36	Lucy K. Mwangi	Good Testimony Schools
37	Eva Joan	Good Testimony Schools
38	Rodah Mukuchu	Good Testimony Schools
39	Linet Atitwa	Good Testimony Schools
40	Pamela Onduru	Parent/Teacher
41	Molly Kariuki	Mbokarm Prep School
42	Sophia Wanyeki	Gachie Special School
43	Christine Omollo	Salama Care Organization
44	Egessah Linet	Marion Schools
45	Elizabeth Gitau	Marion Schools
46	Silas Onyango	APHRC
47	Dr. Ciriaka Gitonga	University of Embu
48	Ruth Kihui	Gertrudes Hospital
49	Jane Njogu	The Caroline
50	Jane Ndungu	Waldorf Kakuma Project
51	Janette Karimi	Ministry of Health
52	Susan Nderitu	Sign language interpreter
53	Harriet Mbutura	Wendani School
54	Alvin Ezra	Acorn School
55	Geophrey Ouma	Acorn School
56	Immaculate Salaon	Community Initiatives Agenda
57	Lucy Gatua	St. Bhakita School
58	Vinseba Odhiambo	St. Bhakita School
59	Rhoda Nduku	Kerugoya Municipality
60	Gracie Okengo	Matters Childhood
61	Beatrice Oyugi	PATH
62	Victor Olum	Beacon of Hope
63	Nancy Munyi	Dyslexia Kenya

64	Dr. Roseline Olumbe	Daystar University
65	Godfrey Muema	KPSA
66	Dr. Elizabeth Kithuka	Daystar University
67	Murrisa Gitau	The Paediatric Dietician
68	Ellenah Wangui	World Vision
69	Dennis Mutua	Ministry of Health
70	Susan Wamithi	AKU
71	V.K. Muriungi	Niskize
72	Andrew Khasiani	AKU
73	Jane Muiruri	ADAT
74	Dr. John Bosco	Afro Heritage Consultancies
75	Lornah Osendi	Tranquil Med. Centre
76	Yukabeth Kidenda	Co-founder and CEO for Teach for Kenya
77	Maureen Twylah	KBC
78	Emily Khalayi	KBC
79	Patience Wanjiku	KBC
80	Serah Kimani	Damacrest
81	Benard Owino	World Vision
82	Dr. Kange	CIC
83	Dr. George Owino	AFECN
84	Joachim Kamau	Childline Kenya
85	Loisa Nasirumbu Wangalwa	Individual

Sponsors and Partners

Acknowledgement and Thanks to Our Partners and Sponsors:

We would like to extend our heartfelt gratitude and appreciation to the following partners and sponsors for their invaluable support in making the Special Needs Conference a resounding success:

1. **Ministry of Education:** Your commitment to inclusive education has been instrumental in shaping the conference's goals and objectives.
2. **Kenya Institute of Special Education:** Your expertise and dedication to special education have greatly enriched our conference discussions and initiatives.
3. **The Aga Khan University Hospital:** Your support in healthcare and well-being initiatives for children with special needs has been a cornerstone of our conference.
4. **Town Connect - Connect Your World:** Your contribution to building connections within our community has been invaluable in fostering understanding and collaboration.

5. **Matters Childhood:** Your advocacy and involvement in childhood development have added significant depth to our conference's impact.
6. **Dyslexia Organization Kenya:** Your commitment to addressing specific learning needs has been a driving force behind our discussions on inclusivity.
7. **ElimuTab - Fun Way to Learn:** Your innovative approach to education technology has brought a unique dimension to our conference.
8. **SAMIMA RISE Gardens:** Your support in promoting a nurturing environment for children with special needs is deeply appreciated.
9. **ACORN:** Your dedication to community development has resonated with our conference's mission.
10. **Cookies:** Your contribution to the conference has been as sweet as your name, enriching our discussions on childhood development.
11. **KEPSA (Kenya Private Sector Alliance):** Your partnership in advancing the private sector's role in inclusive education has been crucial.
12. **Jubilee Life Insurance:** Your commitment to safeguarding children's futures aligns perfectly with our conference's goals.
13. **Save the Children:** Your unwavering support in child protection and welfare initiatives has been a driving force behind our conference.
14. **Through My Eyes:** Your perspective on children's needs and rights has provided valuable insights for our conference.
15. **East Africa Academy of Childhood Disability:** Your expertise in childhood disability has greatly enriched our discussions and initiatives.
16. **Red Leopard:** Your contribution to creative solutions for children's challenges has been a colorful addition to our conference.
17. **Gertrude's Children's Hospital:** Your dedication to children's health and well-being has been a pillar of support for our conference.
18. **Agimba & Associates Advocates:** Your legal expertise and commitment to child rights have been instrumental in shaping our conference discussions.
19. **CM Advocates LLP:** Your legal support and advocacy for children's rights are deeply appreciated.
20. **World Vision:** Your dedication to improving the lives of children worldwide has been a source of inspiration for our conference.
21. **Rehab Tronic:** Your contributions to healthcare technology have opened new horizons for children with special needs.
22. **Kestrel Manor School:** Your commitment to inclusive education at the school level has been instrumental in shaping our conference's vision.

We sincerely thank each of our partners and sponsors for their unwavering support in creating a more inclusive and supportive environment for children with special needs. Together, we are making a significant difference in these children's and their families' lives. Your generosity and dedication are deeply appreciated.

Challenges and Lessons Learned

Challenges:

1. **Funding:** One of the significant challenges of holding the inclusive education conference was securing funding. Conference requires resources such as venue, equipment, and materials, which can be costly. This led to the change of the venue from KISE to Kasarani Group of Schools.
2. **Attendance:** Ensuring attendance at the conference can be challenging. It required a comprehensive reminder of time to the target audience and encouraged them to attend.
3. **Time constraints:** Planning a conference takes time, and it can be challenging. Time was lost on the first day, and some topics were not covered.

Lessons learned:

1. **Collaboration is key:** The conference requires collaboration between stakeholders, such as educators, parents, and professionals. Working together ensures that the conference meets the needs of all participants.
2. **Planning is essential:** Proper planning is critical to the success of a conference. It is essential to have a clear timeline, budget, and contingency plan in place.
3. **Flexibility is necessary:** unexpected challenges arose during the conference despite careful planning. Being flexible and adaptable helped overcome these challenges.
4. **Continuous improvement:** Evaluating the conference's success can help identify areas for improvement. Feedback from participants can help shape future conferences and ensure they are more effective in achieving their goals.

Recommendations

1. **Develop partnerships:** Building partnerships with organizations and individuals who share the same goals can help secure funding and increase attendance.
2. **Focus on accessibility:** Ensure the conference is accessible to all participants, including those with disabilities. This includes providing sign language interpreters, assistive technology, and accessible venues.
3. **Incorporate diverse perspectives:** Ensure that the conference includes a diverse range of perspectives, including those from different cultures, genders, and backgrounds. This can help promote inclusivity and broaden the conference's impact.
4. **Provide practical resources:** Offer practical resources and tools that participants can use in their work, such as writing materials, research papers, and case studies. This can help ensure that the conference has a lasting impact beyond the event itself.
5. **Foster networking opportunities:** Provide opportunities for participants to network and connect with each other. This can help build a community of like-minded individuals who can continue collaborating and supporting each other after the conference ends.

Photo Gallery



















Conclusion

In conclusion, the 2nd Ubuntu inclusive education conference was a crucial platform that promoted equity and access for all learners. The conference brought educators, policymakers, parents, and other stakeholders together to share ideas, resources, and experiences on creating a more inclusive learning environment. Through this conference, we identified the barriers that hinder learners' success and developed strategies to overcome them. One of the key elements of the 2nd Ubuntu inclusive education conference was developing partnerships. Partnerships between stakeholders were critical in creating a collaborative approach to inclusive education. By working together, we can leverage our strengths, resources, and expertise to create an inclusive learning environment that meets the needs of all learners.

Another critical element of the Ubuntu inclusive education conference was focused on accessibility. Accessibility means ensuring that all learners have equal opportunities to access education regardless of their disabilities, backgrounds, or social status. This requires us to provide adequate resources, such as assistive technology, accessible classrooms, and appropriate curriculums.

Providing practical resources was another crucial element of the conference. Participants could share their real-life experiences and what milestones they have achieved, including children with disabilities. These resources helped bridge the gap between theory and practice and ensured educators had the necessary tools to create an inclusive learning environment.

Finally, fostering networking opportunities was another critical element of the conference. Networking opportunities allowed educators to connect with others working towards creating an inclusive learning environment. These connections provided opportunities for collaboration, sharing of ideas, and support.

In conclusion, the 2nd Ubuntu inclusive education conference was a powerful tool for promoting equity and access for all learners. By developing partnerships, focusing on accessibility, incorporating diverse perspectives, providing practical resources, and fostering networking opportunities, we created a truly inclusive and impactful conference. Let us continue to work together to build a more equitable and inclusive world for all learners.

APPENDIX I

Why Ubuntu? – Mr Chuhi Nyoike

Every people group the world over has peculiar traits used to adapt to their milieus and environments, to thrive in them, and to compete against other people groups in the world. These unique traits, sometimes regarded as culture, define and distinguish these groups from the others on this earth.

The Chinese emphasize harmony amongst themselves, benevolence, righteousness, courtesy, and wisdom, coupled with a command structure and centralized power. This has enabled them to reclaim their ancient position in the world by becoming the second-largest economy in the world.

Indians have friendship and hospitality, mellowness, tolerance and having a good time, spirituality, practicality, and good problem-solving skills, which, like China, is about to see them become the third largest economy in the world.

And so, it is with all people groups, including we Africans. I will use the distinction made by Cheik Anta Diop in his 2-cradle theory, where he clearly defined the opposing diametric traits between Africans and the new cultures we have adopted from our colonizers and former rulers. Diop was the first eminent scholar to show the Ancient Egyptians were indisputably Black Africans and the origin of European erudition and civilization, but that is for another day.

According to him, the African Traits are the Spirit of abundance and Justice, Matriarchy, Emancipation of women, Territoriality, Xenophilia, Cosmopolitanism, Social Collectivism, Material solidarity, Optimism, and a literature emphasizing novel tales and comedy.

These traits and others similar in nature have been encapsulated as the spirit and character of Ubuntu – ‘humanity to others. I am because we are.

All the above abundance, justice, etc., are because we consider the collective before the self. Africans are inherently inclusive in all that we do. The family, clan, village, and tribe precede the self.

As we seek solutions to the problem of inclusion for our differently enabled, neuro-diverse fellow Africans, let us remember who we are truly, and the solutions will avail themselves. Diop went on to define the opposing traits.

Compared to the Indo-European traits of Scarcity and Fortress mentality, warlike nature, Spirit of Survival, Patriarchy, debasement of women, Xenophobia, Parochialism, individualism, Moral solitude, Disgust for existence, Pessimism, and tragic literature.

These are traits diametrically opposed to our inherent and original nature. These would lead to further alienation, ostracization, and exploitation.

If the Chinese and Indians are reclaiming their rightful places, so should we Africans. We, the Black African builders of the Great Pyramid, the Sphinx, the first astronomers and Mathematicians, the origin of most Christian thought and Western civilization and philosophy and science, should, with Ubuntu, retain our top position in the world if we dare.

Ubuntu: I am because we are!

APPENDIX II

Transformative Power of Ubuntu Philosophy- Eva Naputuni Nyoike

Ladies and gentlemen, esteemed colleagues, and fellow advocates and champions of inclusive education, I am honored to share my words with you with a profound sense of purpose and excitement as we gather here to explore the transformative power of Ubuntu philosophy in the realm of special and inclusive education.

Our journey today delves deep into a philosophy that embraces the very essence of human interconnectedness and empathy – a philosophy that has the potential to reshape how we perceive, approach, and foster education for all. Ubuntu, the African philosophy that

underscores the interconnectedness of all human beings, speaks to our shared humanity and the idea that we are all bound in a web of relationships.

As we apply this profound philosophy to the field of special and inclusive education, we are presented with an opportunity to shift paradigms, challenge norms, and create an educational environment that is truly inclusive, nurturing, and empowering.

In Ubuntu, we find the essence of inclusivity. It reminds us that everyone, regardless of their abilities or disabilities, has a unique contribution. As educators, caregivers, advocates, and Inclusion champions, we aim to recognize, celebrate, and amplify these contributions. By doing so, we not only enrich the lives of those with special needs, but we also enrich our own lives and the collective fabric of society. Imagine a classroom where differences are not just tolerated but embraced. A classroom where diversity is not a challenge but a strength.

Through the lens of Ubuntu, we see the potential for collaboration, understanding, and growth. When we uphold the principle that "I am because we are," we foster an environment where empathy and compassion are at the forefront. In such an environment, barriers dissolve, and learning becomes a collaborative journey.

However, applying Ubuntu philosophy in special and inclusive education requires more than just theoretical understanding – it demands concrete action. It calls upon us to rethink curriculum design, teaching methodologies, and assessment strategies.

It urges us to dismantle physical and attitudinal barriers that hinder the full participation of individuals with special needs. It encourages us to create spaces where students feel valued, heard, and empowered to pursue their dreams. The journey we embark upon today is not without challenges. It requires confronting biases, questioning assumptions, and navigating uncharted territories.

Yet, the rewards are immeasurable. As we implement Ubuntu philosophy in special and inclusive education, we shape a generation of individuals who possess academic knowledge and a deep-seated sense of empathy, respect, and understanding for one another. Inclusive education, aligned with the Ubuntu philosophy, is a commitment to nurturing a learning environment where diversity is celebrated and actively integrated into the fabric of our educational practices.

It is about recognizing that every student brings unique experiences, abilities, and perspectives to the table, enriching the collective learning journey. Just as each thread contributes to the strength and beauty of a tapestry, every student contributes to the richness and vitality of our educational community. When we embrace inclusive education through the lens of Ubuntu, we reject discrimination, exclusion, and marginalization.

Instead, we foster an atmosphere of respect, empathy, and collaboration. By valuing and supporting each student's strengths and addressing their needs, we create a space where all can flourish, regardless of background, identity, or ability.

Let us commit ourselves to this noble cause, to the realization that the success of one is intertwined with the success of all. Let us be the catalysts for change in education, embracing Ubuntu as our guiding light. By doing so, we take a step towards a future where education transcends boundaries, where every student, regardless of their abilities, thrives in an environment that nurtures their potential and celebrates their uniqueness.

Let us embark on this journey together – a journey towards a more inclusive, compassionate, and enlightened world through the prism of Ubuntu philosophy.

Thank you for your dedication to creating a world where every student is empowered to thrive. Let us work hand in hand, embracing the Ubuntu philosophy to build a brighter and more inclusive future for all.

I wish you all an inspiring and transformative conference Ubuntu!

Thank you.

Eva Naputuni Nyoike

APPENDIX III

Closing Remarks by KPSA Vice Chairman-Mr. Solomon Munene

Salutation

The Chair of Africa Special Needs Network (ASNEN), Madam Eva Naputuni OGW, who also is the current Chairperson of the Special Needs Education Subcommittee at Kenya Private Schools Association, Public and State officers present, invited guests, School directors and managers, teachers, Partners, Conference Moderators, Conference Organizers, friends, ladies and gentlemen, Good Afternoon. Let's all greet each other with Ubuntu Greetings: "I AM BECAUSE YOU ARE"

As we come to the end of the 2nd Ubuntu Special Needs and Inclusive Education Conference, I wish to appreciate most sincerely all of you for your participation, time, efforts, and sacrifices that you have made to make this Conference a success. Your presence and participation have made the whole difference. I am not passing a vote of thanks, but allow me to appreciate all of us, particularly Madam Eva Naputuni, in an extraordinary way for her passionate and persistent work in Special Needs and Inclusive Education.

Introduction

Inclusive education has remained a big challenge not only in Kenya but in many countries across the globe. Most learners with Special Needs have not been able to access Education, which is one of the fundamental rights of every child in Kenya, as provided for in CoK, 2010.

Divine Call to Inclusivity: Matthew 19:14-15

¹⁴ Jesus said, "Let the little children come to me, and do not hinder them, for the kingdom of heaven belongs to such as these." ¹⁵ When he had placed his hands on them, he went on from there.

· Jesus Christ Himself embraced inclusion and set a good example for all of us to emulate.

Competency-Based Curriculum (CBC)

In 2017, the Government of Kenya launched a new Competency-Based Curriculum (CBC) to replace the previous 32-year-old curriculum and system. The move was welcomed due to long-standing concerns over the former curriculum's preoccupation with examinations, heavy workloads, and a teacher-centered, instructive approach.

KICD developed The Basic Education Curriculum Framework (BECF) to actualize the curriculum reforms. Its purpose is to provide a comprehensive conceptualization of basic education.

The Special Needs Education Curriculum Model is, in my view, one of the most progressive and innovative models in the Education reform process because it allows learners with special needs to learn in consideration of their individual education needs, which aims at the full development of their capabilities and at their independence and social participation.

The Vision of Kenya's Competency – Based Curriculum is to enable every Kenyan to become an Engaged, Empowered, and Ethical Citizen'. Its Mission is 'Nurturing every learner's potential'. Learners with special education needs, like any other learner, have potential that needs to be nurtured, and they also need to become engaged, empowered, and ethical citizens.

The Basic Education Curriculum Framework (BECF) by KICD provides a differentiated curriculum for learners with special needs who may follow the regular curriculum with adaptations and those who may require a specialized curriculum. Provision of a differentiated curriculum is stipulated in the sector policy for learners and trainees with disabilities. Therefore, according to me, one of the greatest milestones that the Curriculum Reforms have achieved is establishing the stage – based curriculum model, which is a big boost to Inclusive Education. This means that all educational institutions (both Public and Private) can now plan, prepare, and admit learners with Special Education Needs. The schools that have already embraced Inclusive Education can only expand and improve their Inclusive Education Programs and aspire to be Model Inclusive Education Schools. It is a hat off to all the schools that have already embraced Inclusive Education!

Notable Challenges

From the discussions we have had during this 2nd Ubuntu Special Needs and Inclusive Education Conference, I have gathered some challenges, though not exhaustively, that remain an impediment to Inclusive Education. These challenges include, among others: -

- 1) Inadequate teacher training.
- 2) Underdeveloped Identification and Assessment processes.
- 3) Limited monitoring and evaluation of special education policies.
- 4) Limited funding.

- 5) Little or Lack of information on Special Needs Education and Care

Giving among the members of the public, parents, and educators.

- 6) Negative attitudes and perceptions on Special Needs Education and

Learners with Special Education Needs.

- 7) Fear to Embrace Special Needs Education

Recommendations

From the preceding, therefore, I wish to join the rest of us in making some recommendations, which, if considered, can help us make considerable progress in achieving Inclusive Education in Kenya: -

- 1) Increased and effective Special Education Needs Assessment and intervention.

- 2) Increased Advocacy and Awareness.

- 3) Increased Funding in the Special Needs Education Sector

- 4) Enhanced Continuous Capacity Building and Development for
educators.

- 5) Review of the Teachers' Training Curriculum to include Mandatory

Compressive Training of Special Needs Education for All Teachers.

- 6) Research and documentation.

- 7) Increased Accessibility to Specialized facilities and Technology.

- 8) Special Incentives by the GoK for Private Education Institutions offering Inclusive Education (If the institution has achieved a set minimum number of learners, let's say 35 learners).

- 9) Tax waiver for all Special Needs Learning facilities and Equipment.

- 10) Free and Easy access to Specialized and General Health and Medical Treatment to all children with special needs in line with the Constitution of Kenya, Article 54 (1) (a);
- 11) Adopt a Multisectoral Approach to Inclusive Education;
- 12) Adopt a Multi-Sectoral Approach to the Legislation Processes and operationalize the recommendations on Education Reforms by the Presidential Working Party on Education Reforms.

Conclusion:

Hummingbird Story, as told by the late Prof Wangari Maathai

The story of the hummingbird is about this huge forest being consumed by a fire. All the animals in the forest come out, and they are transfixed as they watch the forest burning and feel overwhelmed and powerless, except for this little hummingbird. It says I am going to do something about the fire!”

So, it flies to the nearest stream and takes a drop of water. It puts it on the fire and goes up and down, up, and down, as fast as it can. In the meantime, all the other animals, much bigger animals – like the elephant with a big trunk that could bring much more water – are standing there helpless.

And they are saying to the hummingbird, ‘What do you think you can do? You are too little, and your beak is so small that you can only bring a small drop of water at a time.’ But as they continue to discourage it, it turns to them without wasting time, telling them, I am doing the best I can.”

What is the Key Message of the Hummingbird story?

The story has a simple message, as the late Prof. Wangari Maathai sums it up perfectly; “We should always be like a hummingbird. I may feel insignificant, but I certainly don’t want to be like the animals watching as the planet goes down the drain. I will be a hummingbird. I will do the best I can.”

How can we be like the hummingbird?

It is normal to feel discouraged or overwhelmed somewhere in your inclusive education journey. It could feel like you’re swimming upstream, and sometimes it can be tiring to just keep swimming. But don’t belittle what you can do as an individual.

The story challenges the idea that greatness is a prerequisite to success and highlights the hummingbird's commitment and belief in the power of small. The hummingbird might have felt insignificant, with the other animals discouraging it. Still, it was determined to protect its home with each bead of water it carried in its beak. If we all become like hummingbirds and start making minute sustainable changes to our attitudes and perceptions, perhaps our collective effort could change the course of Inclusive Education.

Overcoming challenges.

Yes, we acknowledge that we have numerous challenges to Inclusive Education. However, despite the challenges to Inclusive Education and Caregiving, we must believe in possibilities. We must continue striving and persistently pushing forward THE GENDA OF SPECIAL NEEDS AND INCLUSIVE EDUCATION. We must never give up. We cannot give up on these wonderful children. They are precious gifts from God. They are looking upon us to do something. If you don't, who will?

Challenges come to us to make us better not bitter. There are opportunities for growth and innovation in challenges. In the words of Asad Meah, the CEO & Founder of 'Awaken the Greatness Within' "We don't grow when things are easy; we grow when we face challenges."

Therefore, let's view the challenges to Inclusive Education positively and continue making our contribution towards Special Needs and Inclusive Education.

Hope

We must have Hope. We must have Hope that one Day, we shall have Full Inclusive Education and that our beloved Country will be a model Country to Inclusive Education. Hope is critical towards this realization. In the words of Desmond Tutu, 'Hope is being able to see there is light despite all of darkness.'

Romans 5: 5

Now hope does not disappoint, because the love of God has been poured out in our hearts by the Holy Spirit who was given to us.

Quotable quote:

“Many of the things we need can wait. The child cannot. Right now, is the time his bones are being formed, his blood is being made, and his senses are being developed. To him we cannot answer, ‘Tomorrow’. His name is today.” By Gabriela Mistral.

Thank you and God bless you all.

Solomon Munene

National Vice – Chairman

Kenya Private Schools Association – KPSA